

| SCHOOL OF POLICE SCIENCES & SECURITY STUDIES, NFSU GANDHINAGAR

The Privatization of Political Warfare

**An Overview Report on Global Disinformation Firms
and Narrative Hegemony**

Name: SATYASHEEL

Enroll. No.: 250105001016

(M.Sc. Homeland Security, SPSSS)

1. Introduction:

We have been witnessing the total erosion of the theoretical distinction between war and peace. In the contemporary global order, traditional kinetic engagements are being eclipsed by hybrid threats operating within the "Gray Zone."

This paper analyses the contentious rise of the 'Disinformation-for-Hire' industry as the primary driver of modern political instability. This very space allows state and non-state actors to achieve strategic objectives while remaining below the threshold of conventional military response. Central to this transition is the "*Privatization of Political Warfare*," where private disinformation firms have become the primary kinetic actors in the domain of **subversion**. While **Thomas Rid's** taxonomy of cyber conflict identifies *Sabotage* and *Espionage* as critical, the current market trends seem to have shifted toward *Subversion* - the targeted attempt to undermine authority and social cohesion - because it is cheaper, more pervasive, and offers the ultimate strategic asset: **Attribution**.

For political and economic elites, these firms function as "cyber mercenaries." By commodifying plausible deniability, clients can bypass international norms and legal accountability, launching high-intensity information operations that leaves almost no direct state fingerprints. The scale of this industry is no longer speculative; the *Oxford Internet Institute* identifies and lists 65 specific firms selling computational propaganda services in 48 countries, with more than \$60 million spent on these private contractors since 2009.

{Source: <https://demtech.oii.ox.ac.uk/research/posts/industrialized-disinformation>}

Key Definition – What's Gray Zone?

The "**Gray Zone**" describes a set of activities that occur in the contested arena between routine statecraft (peace) and open warfare (armed conflict). It involves gradualist campaigns - including disinformation, cyber operations, and political coercion - tailored to the vulnerabilities of a target state. These tactics aim to weaken or destabilize an adversary while avoiding clear detection and direct military escalation.

{Source: CSIS and Atlantic Council Analysis}

2. The Neoliberal Genesis:

From Public Relations to Narrative Control

The emergence of disinformation firms is the logical evolutionary byproduct of the shift from *regulated capitalism to neoliberalism*. As corporate profit rates declined between 1965 and 1982, a corporate coalition emerged to advocate for the rollback of the regulatory state. This necessitated a "*professionalized persuasion*" industry to sell policies that favoured elite capitalists over the working class.

The "*Bell Pottinger*" model serves as the blueprint for this transition. Originally built on Tim Bell’s success in securing Margaret Thatcher’s electoral victories through traditional PR, the firm eventually morphed into a ruthlessly "*truth-agnostic*" entity. It moved from managing reputations to actively stirring racial tensions in South Africa and supporting autocrats globally. This transition marks the point where public relations became a weapon of narrative hegemony.

Evolution of Persuasion: Traditional PR vs. Privatized Propaganda

Feature	Traditional PR (Regulated Era)	Privatized Propaganda (Neoliberal Era)
Primary Method	Broadcast commercials and press releases.	Computational propaganda and bot-fuelled trolling.
Strategic Goal	Influencing public opinion through messaging.	Behavioural modification and manufacturing consensus.
Ethical Constraints	Subject to industry standards and transparency.	Truth-agnostic; focused on "changing reality."
Tactical Focus	Broad-spectrum messaging for the general public.	Micro-targeted "prediction products" via surveillance.
Conflict Domain	Information management and diplomacy.	Information warfare and systemic subversion.

This historical shift was accelerated by the technological revolutions of "Surveillance Capitalism," which transformed personal data into a refined fuel for algorithmic radicalization.

3. The Mechanics of Manipulation: *Surveillance Capitalism and Behavioural Modification*

Modern disinformation utilizes the logic of "Platform Capitalism," where data is extracted as a raw material to be refined into "prediction products." Synthesizing the theories of Shoshana Zuboff and Nick Srnicek, we see that the business logic of firms like Cambridge Analytica is not merely to "advertise," but to implement a system of behavioural modification. By treating human experience as a corporate resource, these firms move beyond influencing purchases to manufacturing a "new reality."

This is achieved through the **Firehose of Falsehood** model, a tactical framework designed to overwhelm the target's cognitive defences:

1. **High-Intensity:** Utilizing a continuous, high-volume stream of content across multiple social media "Information Ecosystems" to swamp the audience's attention.
2. **Rapid-Fire:** Disseminating content with a velocity that outpaces the ability of fact-checkers or traditional "Fifth Estate" filters to respond.
3. **Truth-Agnostic:** The objective is not to replace a lie with a specific truth, but to sow enough confusion that the audience loses faith in the possibility of objective reality.
4. **Repetitive:** Exploiting cognitive biases by flooding the ecosystem with consistent narratives, making fabricated claims appear legitimate through sheer volume.

4. Case Studies in Narrative Disruption: *The Industry Leaders*

The following dossiers highlight the methodology of some of the firms that have set the "gold standard" for privatized digital psy-ops.

a) Cambridge Analytica

- **Founder:** Robert Mercer (Hedge fund tycoon); Directed by Steve Bannon.
- **Core Strategy: "Military Psy-Ops Privatized."** Utilized psychographic profiling extracted from Facebook data to influence the 2016 US Election and Brexit.
- **Notable Clients:** Trump 2016 Campaign, Leave.EU.
- **Ultimate Outcome:** Defunct (2018) after a global scandal exposed the weaponization of user data.



Cambridge Analytica used psychographic profiling to deliver personalized fear-based messages.

- **2016 U.S. Election:** Targeted anxious voters with dark ads warning of gun confiscation, open borders, and immigrant threats under Clinton, while portraying Trump as the strong leader draining the swamp and restoring American greatness. They also suppressed liberal turnout with discouraging content.
- **Brexit Campaign:** Micro-targeted disillusioned voters with ads claiming Turkey's EU entry will flood Britain with immigrants, and £350M weekly EU fees could fund the NHS instead - pushing a narrative of lost sovereignty and urging "*take back control*."

Sources:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Facebook%E2%80%93Cambridge_Analytica_data_scandal

<https://www.theguardian.com/news/2018/mar/17/cambridge-analytica-facebook-influence-us-election>

<https://www.nytimes.com/2018/04/04/us/politics/cambridge-analytica-scandal-fallout.html>

<https://www.newyorker.com/news/news-desk/new-evidence-emerges-of-steve-bannon-and-cambridge-analyticas-role-in-brexit>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=F42XWjeku1I>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mpbeOCKZFfQ>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FXdYSQ6nu-M>

b) Archimedes Group

- **Founder:** Elinadav Heymann (**Former Israeli intelligence agent**).
- **Core Strategy: "Changing Reality."** Specialized in coordinated inauthentic behavior to disrupt regional elections and influence domestic policy.
- **Notable Clients:** Various political actors in Africa and Southeast Asia.
- **Ultimate Outcome:** Banned by Facebook for "Change Reality" missions that manipulated regional democratic processes.



Facebook Bans Israeli Firm Over Fake Political Activity
Social-media giant removes inauthentic accounts, content linked to Tel Aviv-based firm Archimedes Group

By Sarah E. Needleman
Updated May 16, 2019 5:49 pm ET



Home News Sport Business Technology Health Culture Arts Travel Earth Audio Video Live

Facebook bans "inauthentic" accounts targeting Africa

17 May 2019

Share Save

Facebook busts Israeli company's campaign to disrupt elections

World May 16, 2019 1:54 PM EDT

JERUSALEM — Facebook said Thursday it banned an Israeli company that ran an influence campaign aimed at disrupting elections in various countries and has canceled dozens of accounts engaged in spreading disinformation.

Nathaniel Gleicher, Facebook's head of cybersecurity policy, told reporters that the tech giant had purged 65 Israeli accounts, 161 pages, dozens of groups and four Instagram accounts.

Although Facebook said the individuals behind the network attempted to conceal their identities, it discovered that many were linked to the Archimedes Group, a Tel Aviv-based political consulting and lobbying firm that boasts of its social media skills and ability to "change reality."

Gleicher said Facebook could not speculate about Archimedes' motives, which "may be commercial or political or for some other strategic goal."



FEBRUARY 7, 2026
CURRENT TOP STORIES



LIVE

Archimedes Group, outed by Facebook for election fakery, works from Holon office

Tol tracks down mysterious political influence firm, banned by social media platform for 'deceptive behavior'; to unmarked, fashionable HQ near Tel Aviv filled with young employees

By SIMONA WEINGLASS
23 May 2019, 10:29 am



Meta AI glasses Meta Quest Explore Meta

Technologies Product News Innovation Public Policy Youth Well-Being Privacy

< Back to Newsroom

META

Removing Coordinated Inauthentic Behavior From Israel

May 16, 2019

- Archimedes created fake networks to fabricate crises and smear opponents.
- **African/Southeast Asian Elections:** Flooded platforms with fraudulent grassroots posts portraying rivals as corrupt foreign puppets or chaos instigators, while elevating clients as national saviours (same concept as of CA's US campaigns). Fake news sites spread rumours of fraud or scandals to demoralize opposition supporters and sow widespread doubt.

Sources:

<https://www.wsj.com/articles/facebook-bans-israeli-firm-over-fake-political-activity-11558030115>

<https://www.timesofisrael.com/archimedes-group-outed-by-facebook-for-election-fakery-works-from-holon-office/>

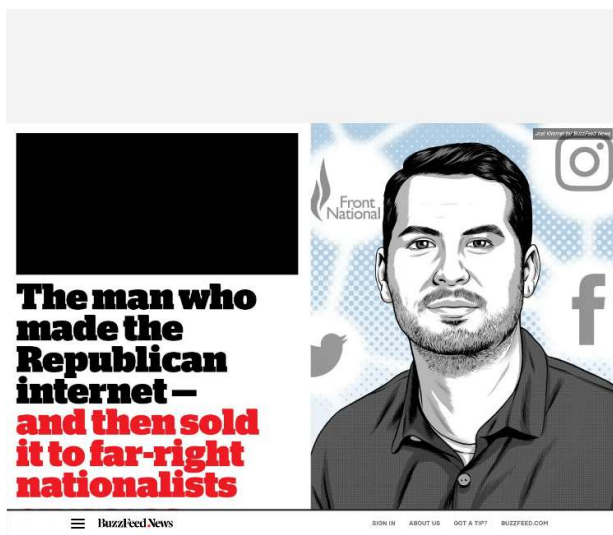
<https://about.fb.com/news/2019/05/removing-coordinated-inauthentic-behavior-from-israel/>

<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/world/facebook-busts-israeli-companys-campaign-to-disrupt-elections>

c) Harris Media & Twinmark Media

- **Founders:** Vincent Harris (Harris Media); Filipino entrepreneurs (Twinmark).
- **Core Strategy: "Republican Internet & Populist Amplification."** Harris Media focused on stoking **tribal divisions in Kenya** and supporting the **far-right AfD in Germany**. Twinmark utilized paid influencers and "fake news" sites to support Rodrigo Duterte.
- **Notable Clients:** Ted Cruz, Benjamin Netanyahu, Uhuru Kenyatta, Rodrigo Duterte.
- **Ultimate Outcome:** Harris Media remains a prominent player in trans-regional campaigns; Twinmark faced massive platform bans in the Philippines.

BuzzFeed News
REPORTING TO YOU



POLITICS

The Man Who Invented The Republican Internet — And Then Sold It To Far-Right Nationalists Overseas

Vincent Harris was once hailed as the top Republican digital strategist in America, combining traditional conservative politics with online and social advertising. In 2017, he's the go-to American consultant for far-right European nationalists like Marine Le Pen and Germany's AfD party. What happened?



Henry J. Clinton
Illustration: Henry J. Clinton

Posted on December 14, 2017 at 9:02 pm

View Comments



POLITICS

AfD party takes on US social media consultant

Jane McIntosh
08/31/2017

Harris Media, a consultant that counts Donald Trump and Britain's right-wing UKIP party as its past clients, is working with Germany's populist AfD party as it seeks election success. A social media blitz is in store.

Medium

Search

The two online campaigns were actually created by **Harris Media LLC**, a far-right American digital media company, on behalf of President Kenyatta's re-election campaign, Privacy International can reveal. Harris Media are a digital advertising and creative agency for primarily political clients. Harris Media uses data analytics to create political campaigns that target audiences using information gleaned from how people use their social media accounts. Its previous clients include the Trump campaign and several far-right European parties.

against rival, new investigation reveals



Privacy International

Follow

11 min read · Dec 14, 2017



DISINFORMATION

Stars, influencers get paid to boost Duterte propaganda, fake news

FEB 27, 2021 10:45 AM PHT

CAMILLE ELEMIA, GEO GONZALES

UPGRADE TO LISTEN

POWERED BY SPEECHIFY

ABS-CBN

News Entertainment Lifestyle Sports Metro Style More

FEATURED:

Marcos 'happy' impeachment 'distractions' over

News

How social media 'influencers' helped Twinmark disseminate fake news

Warren de Guzman, ABS-CBN News

Published Mar 08, 2019 06:55 PM PHT | Updated Mar 08, 2019 08:24 PM PHT



MANILA - "Fake news" – or more accurately, disinformation or misinformation – has spread like wildfire on Facebook in the last few years, thanks in part to so-called social media influencers.

Twinmark Media Enterprises, which was banned by Facebook for exhibiting "coordinated inauthentic behavior," paid social media influencers between P5,000 to P150,000 a month to re-post or share fake news.

Harris Media ran divisive, fear-driven digital campaigns.

- **Kenya 2017:** Through anonymous sites like "*The Real Raila*," stoked ethnic fears by linking opponent Raila Odinga to tribal violence ("Remember 2007 - vote for him means blood"), framing **President Kenyatta** as the protector of peace for loyal communities (same concept as earlier seen).
- **Germany AfD 2017:** Pushed Islamophobic ads like "*Burkas? We prefer bikinis!*" warning of cultural erasure, rape epidemics, and no-go zones-positioning AfD as defender of traditional German identity against Merkel's immigrant "*flood*."

Twinmark paid influencers to amplify pro-Duterte propaganda.

- **Philippines under Duterte:** Coordinated celebrities and meme pages to glorify the drug war as saving children from addicts, smear critics as drug-lord enablers or corrupt elites, and spread fake scandals against opposition-crafting a populist tale of Duterte as the vengeful hero against criminals and oligarchs.

Sources:

[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Vincent_Harris_\(political_strategist\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Vincent_Harris_(political_strategist))

<https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/henrygonzalez/the-man-who-made-the-republican-internet-and-then-sold-it>

<https://www.dw.com/en/germanys-afd-takes-on-trump-campaign-linked-harris-media-for-social-media/a-40306137>

<https://medium.com/@privacyint/texas-media-company-hired-by-trump-created-kenyan-presidents-viral-anonymous-attack-campaign-edd507812039>

<https://www.rappler.com/newsbreak/investigative/celebrities-influencers-get-paid-to-boost-duterte-propaganda-fake-news/>
<https://www.abs-cbn.com/news/03/08/19/how-social-media-influencers-helped-twinmark-disseminate-fake-news>

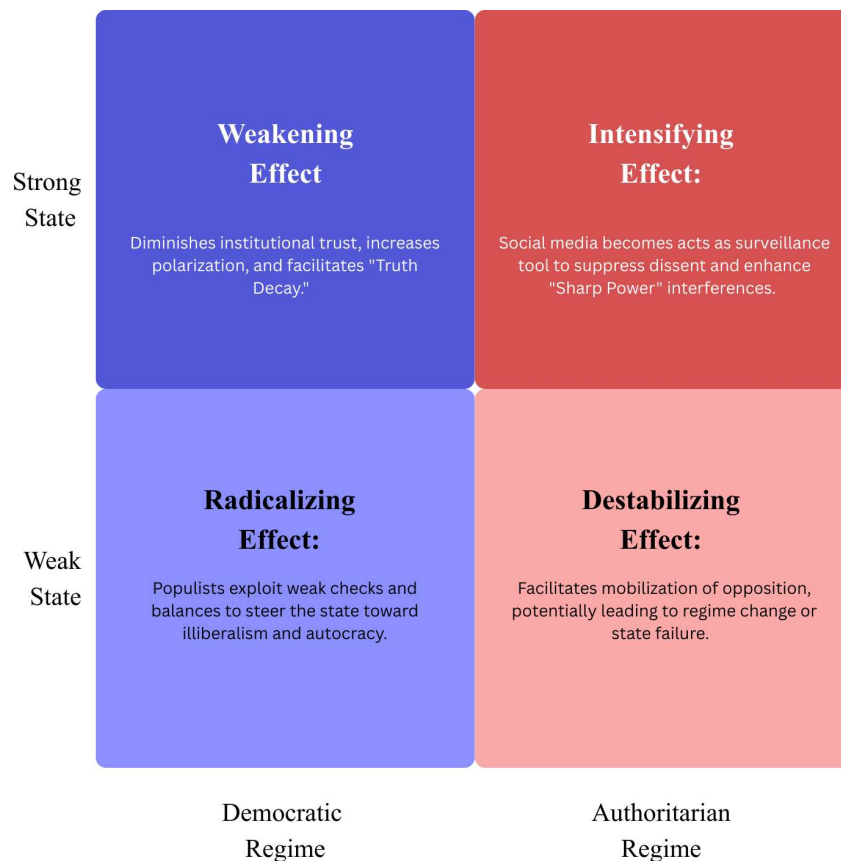
All these firms are embraced by political elites because they offer "Lawfare" and "Sharp Power" capabilities while shielding the client from the consequences of their subversion.

5. The Four-Quadrant Model: Impact on Global Regime Types

The strategic effectiveness of social media manipulation is not uniform. According to the Schleffer & Miller analysis, the outcome of an information operation depends on **State Capacity** and **Regime Type**. The interactions are driven by three primary actors: **domestic opposition, external forces, and the governing regime**.

In strong states, the government maintains a monopoly on the means of violence, which dictates the outcome of any digital spark. In weak states, the lack of institutional checks and balances allows disinformation to metastasize into physical destabilization.

The Matrix of Social Media Manipulation Impact



(Fig: Inspired from <https://tnsr.org/2021/07/the-political-effects-of-social-media-platforms-on-different-regime-types/>)

6. Strategic Outlook: The Future of Truth in a Post-Fact World

The proliferation of private contractors in 48 countries represents a fundamental threat to global security and stability until you are having yours. We have entered the era of "Truth Decay," a phenomenon where the diminishing role of facts in public life makes consensus-building impossible. This is exacerbated by the rise of the "**Fifth Estate**"- tech giants like Facebook and Google that have replaced traditional news outlets but lack the editorial judgment or fact-checking filters required to maintain a healthy information ecosystem.

If these "cyber troop" activities remain unchecked, the concept of the "informed citizen" will become an obsolete nonsense. Strategic responses are being debated, but they carry high risks (western nations – not including India):

- **Platform Bankruptcy:** Resetting follower counts to zero to break the "network effect" of disinformation.
- **Internet Freedom League:** A digital bloc of democratic nations that adhere to shared standards.
- **Regulatory Backlash:** Laws like Germany's *Network Enforcement Act* risk legitimizing state-level censorship, a model already being copied by autocracies to suppress legitimate dissent.

In Summary

- **Subversion as a Service:** Private firms have successfully commodified subversion and plausible deniability, which allows third party to wage political warfare without traditional accountability – resulting – destabilization of country.
- **The Monopoly on Violence:** The ultimate outcome of digital manipulation is still being dictated by state strength; strong states "*weaken*" while weak states "*collapse*." – as evident by real incidents/events.
- **The Surveillance Link:** Disinformation is the front-end of a surveillance system that treats and manipulates the human psyche as a raw material for modification – now utilizing the deep manipulative implementations of AI.

The 'Narrative Truth' of this industry is that it does not create new conflicts, but rather commodifies existing societal fractures for profit, making 'truth' a luxury that only strong states can afford to protect.

Similar pattern: Political Turmoil of Bangladesh

(2024–2025)

The 2024-2025 Bangladesh Crisis as a Living Case Study.

The theoretical models and approached discussed in this paper are evidently observable in the political turmoil of *Bangladesh*. Starting from the *2024 student uprising*, the '*vacuum of legitimacy*' was immediately filled by the exact type of 'Gray Zone' operations defined in Chapter 1. As shown in the data below from **Rumor Scanner**, **Blackbird.ai** and **other sources**, the rapid surge in coordinated disinformation (a **52% increase**) illustrates how external and internal vectors weaponized the 'narratives' during 2024-2025 - a textbook application of the '*Weak State / Destabilizing Effect*' quadrant."



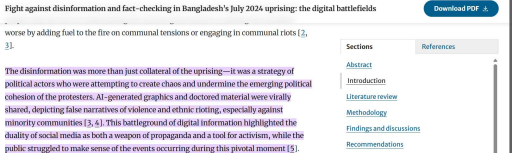
(source: <https://www.aljazeera.com/features/2026/2/1/deeply-insecure-why-bangladeshi-minorities-are-scared-ahead-of-elections>)



(source: <https://thediplomat.com/2024/08/bangladeshs-new-democracy-under-threat-from-flood-of-misinformation>)



(source: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s44282-026-00337-2#:~:text=As%20the%20uprising%20unfolded%2C%20it,or%20making%20the%20situation%20worse>)



(source: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s44282-026-00337-2#:~:text=The%20disinformation%20was%20more%20than,5>)

Center and vandalized fiber-optic cables in other parts of the country.

Bangladesh State Minister for Posts, Telecommunication, and Information Technology Zunaid Ahmed Palak said the government implemented the shutdown of mobile networks to limit the spread of “fake news.” Though broadband internet service was restored on July 25, and mobile networks were reinstated on July 28, disruptions to social media and mobile data continue.

(source: <https://blackbird.ai/blog/disinformation-powered-narrative-attacks-contribute-to-unrest-and-violence-across-bangladesh/#:~:text=Bangladesh%20State%20Minister%20for%20Posts%2C,July%2025%2C%20and%20mobile%20networks>)

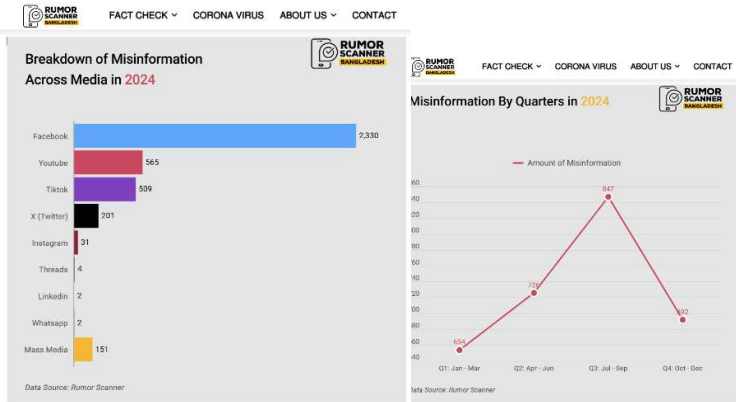
RUMOR SCANNER FACT CHECK CORONA VIRUS ABOUT US CONTACT ENGLISH

The chain of events began with Bangladesh's 12th National Parliamentary Election, followed by a persistent surge of misinformation intertwined with various unfolding issues. However, the historic months of July and August proved pivotal. The quota reform movement ignited a mass student uprising that ultimately led to the ousting of Sheikh Hasina's Awami League government after a prolonged period in power. In the aftermath, an interim government led by Dr. Yunus assumed state authority. Following this political shift, several Indian media outlets and X accounts launched a coordinated wave of communal propaganda targeting Bangladesh. Amid these turbulent developments, 2024 drew to a close. Throughout the year, Bangladesh's leading fact-checking organization, Rumor Scanner, worked relentlessly to combat the spread of misinformation, identifying a record-breaking 2,919 instances of false claims—a sharp rise from the 1,915 cases reported in 2023, reflecting a staggering 52% surge in misinformation within a year.

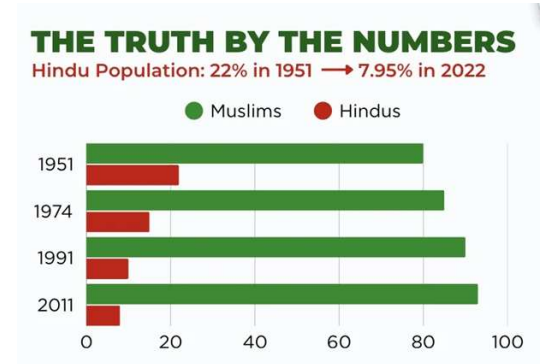
Misinformation Peaks in January Amid Election, 577 Cases Identified [FACT FILE]

Polls, Lies, and Polarization: Students Sound the Alarm on Election Disinformation [13TH NATIONAL]

(source: <https://rumorscanner.com/en/statistics-2/rumors-data-2024/134624#:~:text=Throughout%20the%20year%2C%20Bangladesh%E2%80%99s%20leading,in%20misinformation%20within%20a%20year>)



(source: <https://rumorscanner.com/en/statistics-2/rumors-data-2024/134624>)



(source: <https://cohna.org/bangladeshi-hindus-genocide>)

WIKIPEDIA 25 years of the free encyclopedia

2024 Bangladesh anti-Hindu violence

Article Talk Read Edit View history Tools

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

This article has multiple issues. Please help improve it or discuss these issues on the talk page. (Learn how and when to remove these messages)

- The neutrality of this article is disputed. (April 2025)
- This article may need to be rewritten to comply with Wikipedia's quality standards. (November 2024)

Following the resignation of Sheikh Hasina on 5 August 2024, attacks began on Hindus in Bangladesh, with Hindu homes, businesses and places of worship being targeted en masse.^[10] The Bangladesh Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council reported that from 4 to 20 August, a total of 2,010 incidents (including 69 temples) of attacks on minorities took place across the country within this 16-day period.^[11]

2024 Bangladesh anti-Hindu violence

Part of the post-resignation violence and the aftermath of July Revolution

Location Bangladesh

Target Hindus of Bangladesh^[10]

(source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2024_Bangladesh_anti-Hindu_violence#:~:text=The%20Bangladesh%20Hindu%20Buddhist%20Christian,within%20this%2016%Dday%20period.)